RAMBAM'S INTRODUCTION TO HELEK: OLAM HABA & THE 13 PRINCIPLES

Mashiah: Principle 12

Rambam's Introduction to Helek, Part 17

Source: The Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek: Principle 12 (the days of Mashiach), with **Hilchot Melachim 11–12**

Shiur: Part 17 of the series on the Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom, Tuesday 10 February 2026

These notes are based on the transcript of the recording.

Where We Are

"**Coming to the end** of the Rambam's introductions: the final one, to **Perek Chelek**, whose second part is **the Thirteen *Ikkarim***."

Category	Principles
Hashem	1–5
Revelation: prophecy, Moshe, the Torah not changing	6–9
Consequences and eschatology: Hashem's knowledge (10), **consequences of our actions** (11, last week), **Mashiach** (12), ***Techiyat HaMetim*** (13)	10–13

"**We've already seen some discussion of Mashiach in this *hakdamah***, so tonight: **the points we haven't covered yet**."

Part 1: The Text

היסוד השנים עשר: ימות המשיח. והוא להאמין ולאמת שיבוא, ולא יחשוב שיתאחר, ״אם יתמהמה חכה לו״. ולא ישים לו זמן, ולא יעשה לו סברות במקראות להוציא זמן ביאתו. אמרו חכמים: ״תפח רוחן של מחשבי קצין״. ושיאמין שיהיה לו יתרון ומעלה וכבוד על כל המלכים שהיו מעולם, כפי שנבאו עליו כל הנביאים, ממשה רבנו עליו השלום עד מלאכי עליו השלום. ומי שיסתפק בו או נתמעטה אצלו מעלתו, כפר בתורה, שהעידה בו בפירוש בפרשת בלעם ובפרשת אתם נצבים. ומכלל יסוד זה, שאין מלך לישראל אלא מבית דוד ומזרע שלמה בלבד, וכל החולק על המשפחה הזאת כפר בשם יתברך ובדברי נביאיו.

Five elements

#	Element	Source
1	**Mashiach will come**	**להאמין ולאמת שיבוא**
2	**Await him, even if he delays**	**אם יתמהמה חכה לו** (**Chavakuk 2:3**)
3	**Don't calculate the time**, nor build arguments from verses	**תפח רוחן של מחשבי קצין** (**Sanhedrin 97b**): "**may the bones of those who calculate the end wither**"
4	**His greatness above all kings** who ever were	Prophesied **from Moshe to Malachi**. **Doubting him, or diminishing his greatness, is denying the Torah**
5	**From the House of David, the seed of Shlomo alone**	**לא יסור שבט מיהודה**. Disputing the family = **denying Hashem and His prophets**

"**Primarily, Mashiach is a king.** It's important to recognise that."

Part 2: Where Is Mashiach in the Torah? (Hilchot Melachim 11:1)

המלך המשיח עתיד לעמוד ולהחזיר מלכות דוד ליושנה לממשלה הראשונה, ובונה המקדש, ומקבץ נדחי ישראל, וחוזרין כל המשפטים בימיו כשהיו מקודם: מקריבין קרבנות, ועושין שמטין ויובלות... וכל מי שאינו מאמין בו, או מי שאינו מחכה לביאתו, לא בשאר נביאים בלבד הוא כופר, אלא בתורה ובמשה רבנו.

The Messianic king will…
Restore David's kingdom to its former glory
Build the Temple
Gather Israel from the four corners of the world
Restore the laws: **sacrifices**, **Shemittah and Yovel**

"Doesn't believe in him, *or doesn't await his coming*." "**Waiting seems to be an essential part.**"

In the Prophets it's everywhere: "he doesn't need a source for that." As throughout the principles, **the Rambam wants a source in the Torah itself**:

Parashah	Verse	Reading
Nitzavim	**ושב ה׳ אלהיך את שבותך ורחמך, ושב וקבצך מכל העמים... אם יהיה נדחך בקצה השמים, משם יקבצך... והביאך ה׳ אלהיך**	**The ingathering**: "a prelude to all the prophecies"
Balak	**Bilaam's final prophecy**: **two *meshichim***	Below

The two Messiahs: משיח הראשון שהוא דוד, שהושיע את ישראל מיד צריהם; ומשיח האחרון שעומד מבניו, שמושיע את ישראל באחרונה. "**David was in a sense the first *Melech HaMashiach*: not the final one, but the first**."

Verse (Bamidbar 24:17)	The Rambam
אראנו ולא עתה	**David**
אשורנו ולא קרוב	**The final Mashiach**
דרך כוכב מיעקב	**David**
וקם שבט מישראל	**The *Melech HaMashiach***

(After three attempts to curse turned to blessing, Balak says "thank you, time to go"; Bilaam: let me tell you a bit about them*, their future grandeur.)*

Part 3: The Ani Ma'amin and Yigdal

	Text	Covers
Ani Ma'amin	**אני מאמין באמונה שלמה בביאת המשיח, ואף על פי שיתמהמה, עם כל זה אחכה לו בכל יום שיבוא**	**Coming and waiting**. **"Every day" is an addition**: "**these two words may be problematic**"
Yigdal	**ישלח לקץ ימין משיחנו, לפדות מחכי קץ ישועתו**	**Coming and waiting**

***Ketz yamin*, with a final *nun*! "I've always thought it was *yamim with a mem. Looking now, it's yamin, a play on yamim*: days. I wonder if anyone notices when they sing it."**

Both stress not only the coming but the waiting.

"In distinction to other religions in which the Mashiach has already come": "Rabbi Sacks used to talk about this a lot. It's a source of hope: we **haven't yet experienced the Golden Age**; we're **awaiting the redemption of mankind**. **There's comfort in that.**"

Part 4: What "Mashiach" Means

Root מ־ש־ח: to anoint, to smear. Both **the Kohen** and **the king** were anointed with oil: the Kohen Gadol is ***HaKohen HaMashiach***.

"**At the coronation after Queen Elizabeth passed away**, an essential part of the ceremony was **the oil from Jerusalem**."

Mashiach is **primarily a king**, so he's **"the anointed"**; but ***HaMashiach*, the** anointed one: **the finale, the highest of all the kings**. "**That's where the Rambam gets his greatness above all kings.**"

Part 5: Waiting (*Tzippita LiYeshuah*)

How we wait in practice: the Amidah

Berachah	Words
Teka BeShofar	תקע בשופר גדול לחרותנו, ושא נס לקבץ גלויותינו... ברוך אתה ה׳ מקבץ נדחי עמו ישראל: **an essential task** of Mashiach "**the ingathering**, "
Et Tzemach David	את צמח דוד עבדך מהרה תצמיח, וקרנו תרום בישועתך, כי לישועתך קוינו כל היום
(***Hashivah Shofteinu***, ***VeLiYerushalayim***)	**Restoring the judges, the Sanhedrin, Yerushalayim**: "**not specifically Mashiach**"

"We pray for **wisdom, *parnassah*, health**: people focus there, and **towards the later *berachot* we lose focus**. **But two (or three) are about Mashiach.** Praying them **three times a day**, or as women do, **that's how we fulfil awaiting Mashiach**."

The source

Shabbat 31a: among the questions asked of a person **after 120**: **צפית לישועה? Did you await the salvation?**

Is waiting really part of the principle?

The Rambam says so here and in Mishneh Torah (**או מי שאינו מחכה לביאתו**). **The Brisker Rav** wrote a lot on this: **the principle is to believe *and* await.**

"**The difficulty:** to call someone who **believes but doesn't actively await** a **denier of a principle**: **quite severe, quite harsh. So others reinterpret it. It doesn't seem like that to me.** Perhaps **because it's so distant**, **believing intellectually isn't enough; you have to live with it**, and **that's waiting**."

"Every day"?

The Ani Ma'amin's *bechol yom* isn't in the Rambam. "**The Gemara says there are times Mashiach can't come**: **Shabbat and Yom Tov**, and so on." "**I don't know if the Rambam meant every single day.** The point is **it's in your mind, regularly**."

The Chafetz Chaim (R. Yisrael Meir HaKohen): "**it's told he had a suit and a suitcase packed** for Mashiach. **Legend or not, it's only 100 years ago, so it's very likely true.**"

Part 6: Don't Calculate

Why does the Rambam put this right after waiting? "**Calculate a date and you've said *he's coming then*, in however many years. That pushes it off and stops you thinking he can come at any moment.**"

The Rambam never calculated: forbidden, **and part of this principle**. **Ibn Ezra** also forbids it. **Yet:**

Calculated a date	Roughly
Rav Saadia Gaon	**20–30 years after his own death**
The Ramban	**The 1200s** ("I think")
Abarbanel	**The 1500s**
The Malbim	**The 1900s**

"**Many great Chachamim calculated dates. And the reality is they were all wrong.**"

Defending them: "**The most basic answer**: these weren't **definitive** dates but **yearnings and hopes**: **a ripe time** for Mashiach."

The Rambam's reply: "**Even predicting a ripe time 10 or 20 years off takes away from the yearning. Don't do this. It's forbidden. Stay away.**"

Will: *The Talmud often mentions 6,000 years. Would the Rambam say that's the wrong approach?*

"**Excellent question.** Two points:

1. **No one in the Talmud makes a calculation.** The calculations are by **later authorities**. **The 6,000 years says the *world* will exist 6,000 years**, not that Mashiach comes by then (though that would follow).

2. **The Rambam says explicitly it's not to be taken literally**: **one opinion we don't follow**, or read differently. **It could be longer, even eternal. No 6,000-year limit**."

Part 7: A Process, Not a Moment

"**Not going into it tonight**, but **the Rambam 100% believes it's a gradual process**, and so did **Rav Saadia**: **not from one moment to the next**."

Where are we going? "**Towards Eretz Yisrael**: **full sovereignty**, the **Beit HaMikdash** rebuilt, the **Sanhedrin** sitting again, as a sovereign nation lived in Temple times, **like the empires of David and Shlomo**, when **all the nations around came**."

Rav Kook and many others saw **the rebirth of the State of Israel** as **the beginning of the process**. "**Historically it's never happened that a nation is exiled twice and returns**: **Babylon (Iraq)**, back; **Rome**, back a **third** time. **And the miracles of the State today, I think, are pretty clearly supernatural. Of course there's much more to do: many faults and problems, and we're clearly not sovereign: all the wars we've been at.** But **it's the beginning**."

Part 8: A Person or an Era?

For the Rambam, Mashiach is an actual person: **"he will come"**, **"greatest of all kings"**. **Not just a concept or an era.** But some thought otherwise.

Midrash Tanchuma: אמר הקב״ה: בעולם הזה הייתם נושעים על ידי בני אדם: in Egypt **Moshe**; under Sisera **Devorah and Barak**; against Midian… the **Judges**; **ועל ידי שהיו בשר ודם, הייתם חוזרים ומשתעבדים**: **human saviours, so it didn't last**. **לעתיד לבוא: אני בעצמי גואל אתכם, ושוב אין אתם משתעבדים**, as it says **ישראל נושע בה׳ תשועת עולמים**.

Rav Menachem Kasher (***Torah Shelemah***, the last 150 years):

- **Hoshea, Yeshayahu, Michah, Yirmiyahu and Zechariah** speak of **a specific human Mashiach**.

- **Nachum, Tzefaniah, Chavakuk, Malachi, Yoel and Daniel** don't.

So **perhaps not necessarily a person**. "**I think that's very, very difficult. The Rambam would certainly disagree.**"

Part 9: Rabbi Hillel's "No Mashiach"

Sanhedrin 99a: רבי הלל אומר: אין להם משיח לישראל, שכבר אכלוהו בימי חזקיה. There's no Mashiach for Israel; they already "consumed" him in Chizkiyahu's day.

May his Master forgive Rabbi Hillel! Chizkiyahu was in the **First Temple**, yet **Zechariah**, in the **Second**, prophesied Mashiach still to come. **אמר רב יוסף: שרי ליה מריה לרבי הלל!**

Rashi: אין להם משיח לישראל, אלא הקב״ה ימלוך בעצמו ויגאלם לבדו: Rabbi Hillel **didn't deny a Messianic era**, only **a personal individual Messiah**; **the prophecies of a person were fulfilled in Chizkiyahu**. "**Already in Rashi**: **collective redemption** rather than **an individual leading the way**."

Rav Yosef Albo's challenge (*Sefer Halkkarim*, the opening)

"**A book of principles that begins by saying principles are dangerous.**"

The Rambam counts Mashiach as a principle, and whoever denies a principle is **a heretic with no portion in Olam HaBa**. **וזה דבר מתמיה מאד**: Rabbi Hillel, **אחד מחכמי ישראל הנזכרים בתלמוד**, said *ein Mashiach*, so **by the Rambam he'd be a *kofer***. **Then why does the Gemara give him that honoured title?** "**When the Gemara cites someone to refute him, it's in derogatory terms. Not here.**"

Albo **rejects the reinterpretations** (**"may he be forgiven" means he *was* wrong**) and concludes: **בלי ספק רבי הלל לא היה מאמין בביאת המשיח כלל, ואף על פי כן לא היה נקרא כופר אינה עיקר לתורת משה**, because **ביאת המשיח**: the Torah **can exist without it**.

	Mashiach is…	Denier is…
The Rambam	**A principle of faith**	**A heretic**, no portion in Olam HaBa
Albo	**A true belief every Jew must hold**, but **not foundational**	**Wrong, not a *kofer***, like one who holds **creation from pre-existing matter** (Principle 4)

"**That's one of Albo's big proofs against the Thirteen Principles.**" *(Others: Rashi's era reading; or Mashiach without miracles.)*

"I'm relying on Rabbi Hillel": the Chatam Sofer

The Chatam Sofer (R. Moshe Sofer, ~250 years ago) was asked exactly this. **Today you *would be a kofer***.

"**Like halachah:** two views in the Gemara, sometimes on huge matters; **once the *psak is given, it must be followed. A chacham who sticks to his view against the Sanhedrin's ruling: terrible things can happen to him."***

"The same in theology. Everyone now holds there will be a Messianic era. You can't say I eat chicken and dairy because Rabbi Yosei HaGelili did."

And Rabbi Hillel himself? "Then there was no psak: it was his view, and **he probably changed it** once he saw the consensus."

"**Today everyone would agree a person must believe in Mashiach. Deny it: per the Rambam, a heretic; per Albo, wrong but not a heretic**, like other beliefs, e.g. **Gan Eden**, which **the Rambam says clearly is not one of the principles**."

Part 10: The Seed of Shlomo?

Rav Kafich, "**authoritative on the Rambam's thought in many ways**": **not to be taken literally**.

- **He doesn't know the Rambam's source**, and **some Gemarot suggest otherwise**.

- **Throughout Mishneh Torah**, whenever the Rambam discusses Mashiach, **he says only *the House of David, never Shlomo***.

- **His suggestion:** the Rambam added Shlomo **to counter the Christian genealogy of Jesus through *Natan* son of David**. "**I wouldn't say hyperbole**, but **not an essential part**."

Part 11: How Do We Recognise Mashiach? (Hilchot Melachim 11:3–4)

"Don't think the Mashiach must perform miracles, do new things, or revive the dead."

Proof: Rabbi Akiva, a great *chacham* of the Mishnah, **was Bar Kozba's arms-bearer**, and he and **many sages of his generation** thought him Mashiach **until he was killed**. **They never asked him for a miracle.**

Stage	Criteria	Status
1	**From the House of David** (note: ***David***, not Shlomo); **studies Torah and keeps the mitzvot like David**, **Written and Oral**; **leads Israel in the Torah's ways**; **fights the wars of Hashem**	**בחזקת שהוא משיח**: **presumed** Mashiach
2	**אם עשה והצליח, ובנה מקדש במקומו, וקבץ נדחי ישראל**	**משיח בודאי**: **certainly** Mashiach
Failed	Didn't succeed, **or was killed**	"**We were wrong.**" **Like other good kings who died**: not necessarily **a false Mashiach**, just **a wrong assumption**

Jesus and "the Yishmaeli who followed"

The Rambam: people thought **Yeshu HaNotzri** was Mashiach, and he was killed. **Why would Hashem allow that?** "***Machshevot haBorei***: we don't fully understand Hashem's ways."

"**Notice: whenever the Rambam refers to Jesus he names him; Muhammad he never names**": **וכל הדברים האלו של ישו הנוצרי ושל זה הישמעאלי שעמד אחריו**. "**He had no respect for Muhammad.**"

אינן אלא לישר דרך למלך המשיח: **only to pave the way for the King Mashiach**. **Christianity dominates the world, and so *the idea of Mashiach* has spread everywhere**; "when the true Mashiach comes,

".**they'll realise they were wrong**

"The wars of Hashem": physical or spiritual?

"**Famously, many believed the Lubavitcher Rebbe** was Mashiach. **The son of Rav Mordechai Eliyahu**, Rav Yosef Eliyahu, **told me his father used to say the Lubavitcher Rebbe maybe was Mashiach in his time. But he's died. And he went to no wars that I know of.** So **Chabad say the wars of Hashem are spiritual wars**."

"**I don't think that's what the Rambam means**: it's **in the same paragraph as Bar Kozba**, who **fought physical wars**, the **revolt against Rome**, successful for a time. **The simple reading is physical wars. Front line or in the background? I don't know.** He **leads a people who win wars and take back sovereignty** of Eretz Yisrael."

"**Nowhere** in Mishneh Torah or this principle does the Rambam say Mashiach needs **prophetic powers** or to be **a miracle worker**."

Will he be a rabbi?

"**He studies, knows and teaches Torah and keeps the mitzvot**: if that's not a rabbi, what is? **But he needn't have the title. Many people do all of that and aren't rabbis**, and **they'd be fully able to be Mashiach**." **"A rabbi and a warrior."**

Part 12: What Happens Then? (Hilchot Melachim 12)

Life continues as usual, with two differences:

1. Sovereignty	"**No more UN resolutions, no more wars**: completely sovereign"
2. Freedom from the burdens of making a living	"**Not that money grows on trees**, nor **clothes**, as some passages indicate; nor **the wolf literally dwelling with the sheep**: **metaphors for peace and tranquillity**"

Hilchot Melachim 12:4: לא נתאוו החכמים והנביאים ימות המשיח... אלא כדי שיהיו פנויין בתורה וחכמתה, ולא יהיה להם נוגש ומבטל, כדי שיזכו לחיי העולם הבא.

We long for Mashiach only to be free for Torah and wisdom, with **nothing to hinder us**, **so as to merit Olam HaBa**.

"**This is key.** As we explained last week, **Olam HaBa is the direct consequence of one's moral and intellectual development**. In Messianic times **we'll have more time for it**. **A person today who's financially stable and free to sit and learn is already, in a sense, living in the times of Mashiach.**"

"**Free will remains. Life continues as usual. But Israel is sovereign**, and we're **far freer to develop our intellect, pursue wisdom and keep the mitzvot**."

Summary

1. **Principle 12, five elements:** Mashiach **will come**; **await him** even if he delays; **don't calculate**; he'll be **greater than all kings**; **from David** (and Shlomo).
2. **Torah sources: Nitzavim** (the ingathering) and **Balak** (**two Messiahs: David and the last**).
3. **Mashiach = the anointed king**, *the* anointed one.

4. **Waiting is part of the principle** (**צפית לישועה**; **the Brisker Rav**): we do it in the **Amidah**. **"Every day"** is the Ani Ma'amin's addition.
5. **Calculating** pushes him away. **Rav Saadia, the Ramban, Abarbanel and the Malbim** did it, as **"ripe times"**, **and were all wrong**. **The 6,000 years** isn't a deadline, and **the Rambam doesn't take it literally**.
6. **A gradual process**: **Rav Kook** and **the State of Israel** as its beginning.
7. **A person, not just an era** (vs **Rashi on Rabbi Hillel**, **Rav Kasher**). **Rabbi Hillel's denial**: **Albo** says not a *kofer*, because **Mashiach isn't foundational**; **the Chatam Sofer**: after the *psak*, **today you would be**.
8. ***Seed of Shlomo***: **Rav Kafich**, **anti-Christian emphasis**, absent from Mishneh Torah.
9. **Recognising him: Torah, mitzvot, leadership, the wars of Hashem** (**physical**, the Rabbi argues) → **presumed**; **Temple and ingathering → certain**. **No miracles required** (**Rabbi Akiva and Bar Kozba**). **Jesus and Muhammad** "paved the way."
10. **Messianic times**: **sovereignty and freedom to learn**, **for the sake of Olam HaBa**.

Coming Up

Next week: Principle 13, *Techiyat HaMetim*, "**the final, or penultimate, shiur on this**; I'll try to make it the final." Then, in a few weeks, **the Moreh Nevuchim**.

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/JN_uI33QIgw · More shiurim: rabbikada.com